Shadow Box

By Michael Cristofer

BEVERLY: Surprise! Oh, who are you? I'm sorry. I'm looking for Brian . . . uh . . . Two. They said cottage two. I must have . . .

MARK: No. This is two. This is cottage two.

BEVERLY: Oh ! Thank God. Is . . . uh . . . .

MARK: No. Not at the moment. But he should be back any minute.

BEVERLY: Good. I wanted to surprise him and he's not here. Well, Surprise! Hmmm. Very nice. Very nice. All the comforts of home. Amazing what you can do with a coffin if you put your mind to it.

MARK: What?!

BEVERLY: Oh, sorry. Sorry. Introductions first. That way you'll know who you're throwing out. I'm Beverly. No doubt you've . . .

MARK: Yes. Brian's wife.

BEVERLY: Ex-wife

MARK: Former

BEVERLY: Yes. Former. He prefers former, doesn't he.

MARK: Yes. I figured it was you.

BEVERLY: And you're . . . uh . . .

MARK: Mark

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *In this scene from Michael Cristofer's The Shadow Box, Beverly, Brian's ex-wife, and Mark, Brian's gay lover, meet for the first time.*

ACTOR: *And although the circumstances of this meeting would never be ideal – this meeting occurs because Brian is dying.*

ACTRESS: *Now we know what you're thinking . . . AIDS, right?*

ACTOR: *Wrong. Now, we don't blame you for jumping to that conclusion. The media has pushed the horror of AIDS for quite some time.*

ACTRESS: *But unfortunately, it has been to the detriment of other illnesses that lead to an even greater death toll.*

ACTOR: *Cancer kills more people every six weeks than AIDS is projected to kill this year.*
ACTRESS: *And that "less publicized" but equally devastating disease is what has brought Beverly and Mark together today.*
TOGETHER: *The Shadow Box by Michael Cristofer*

BEVERLY: Well, now that we know who we are . . . how about a drink?

MARK: A what? Oh, no. We don't keep any liquor here. I could get you some coffee or some penicillin, if you'd like

BEVERLY: No. No. I was inviting you. I had an accident with the scotch on the way out here. There's quite a dent in it. Anyway, we both look like we could use a little. Hmm?

MARK: No. I don't drink.

BEVERLY: Ah, a dope man.

MARK: Neither. I like to avoid as much poison as possible.

BEVERLY: I see.

MARK: Well, you go ahead if you feel you have to.

BEVERLY: No. No, really. I don't need it. I mean. I'm not . . . Forget it. So. How is he?

MARK: Dying. How are you?

BEVERLY: Ooooops. Let's start again. Is he feeling any pain?

MARK: Are you?

BEVERLY: Strike two. Well, think we've got it all straight now. He's dying. I'm drunk. And you're pissed off. Did I leave anything out?

MARK: No. I think that just about covers it.

BEVERLY: Tell me. How is he?

MARK: Hard to say. One day he's flat on his ass, the next day he's running around like a two-year-old. But he is terminal – officially. He has fainting spells. They're harmless. Well, that's what they tell me. But it's embarrassing for him because he falls down a lot and his face gets a little purple for a minute. I just want you to know. If you're staying around. I mean, I think it would hurt him if people noticed.

BEVERLY: Well, if he turns purple and falls on the floor, it'd be sort of difficult not to notice, wouldn't it?

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MARK: Look. I don't mean to be rude or stupid about this . . .

BEVERLY: Why not? I like people to be rude and stupid. It's one of the ways you can be sure they're still alive.

MARK: You're very stoned aren't you? And you're dressed in funny clothes, and you're saying a lot of funny things but I'm just not sure, frankly, what you're doing here.

BEVERLY: Neither am I.

MARK: . . . . when I met Brian, I was hustling outside a bar in San Francisco. Right after the great "Summer of Love." People were starving to death in the streets.

BEVERLY: Sounds lovely.

MARK: Like everybody else, I was very hungry, very desperate. So there I was one night, selling it down on Market Street. I wasn't very good at it, and Brian walks up to me . . . and asks me the time. Right? Well, I did my little number about time for what and how much it was worth to him . . . and all of a sudden, he starts explaining exactly what time was worth to him . . . time warps even! Jesus, I though, I've got a real freak on my hands. And he's talking and talking and talking. Finally, I say "Look man, I haven't eaten in a long time, and I'm getting a headache. Why don't we talk some business before I starve to death?"

BEVERLY: What did he do?

MARK: He bought me dinner! I couldn't believe it. I mean, what did he want from me? And he never stopped talking. Never.

BEVERLY: He didn't want anything from you.

MARK: It doesn't matter, and that's how I got to know him. I got interested in what he was doing. He gave me a room. I could use it whenever I wanted. We talked and talked endlessly. What am I talking about?

BEVERLY: Dead people.

MARK: Exactly! I mean, exactly!

BEVERLY: Exactly what?

MARK: I mean it's not enough! We are dying here lady. That's what it's about. Brian looks at me and I can see it in his eyes. You can wipe up the mucous and the blood and the piss. You

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can burn the sheets and boil his clothes, but it's still there. You can smell it on him. You can smell it on me. It's sick and putrid and soft and rotten and it's killing me.

BEVERLY: It's killing him too.

MARK: That's right, lady. And some of us have to watch it. Some of us have to live with it and clean up after it. Some of us are here for the duration. . . . And it's not easy.

BEVERLY: And some of us wouldn't mind changing places with you at all.

MARK: And some of us just don't care anymore.

BEVERLY: What?

MARK: Some of us just don't care.

BEVERLY: You're cute, Mark. But next to me, you are the most selfish *person* I've ever met.

MARK: Oh, wonderful! That's exactly what I needed. Yes, sir. That's just what I needed.

BEVERLY: Let me tell you something– what you do is your business. You can drag *yourself* through every gutter from here to Morocco. You can trade it, sell it, or give it away. I don't care. I'll even show you the best way to do it. But Brian is different. Because Brian is different. Because Brian is stupid. Because Brian is blind. Because Brian doesn't know where you come from or who you come from or why or how or even what you are coming to. Because Brian happens to need you. And if that is not enough for you, then you get yourself out of his life – fast.

MARK: That simple, huh?

BEVERLY: When the money and the time and the people are all running out faster than you can count, and the reasons don't sound as good as they used to and you don't remember any more why . . . why you walked out on the one person who said yes, you do what you have to because I love you. And you can't remember anymore what it was you thought you had to do or who you thought you were that was so important that you couldn't hang around long enough to say goodbye or find out what it was you were saying goodbye to . . . One human being who cares. My God, why isn't that ever enough?

MARK: You want an answer to that?

BEVERLY: I want you to get yourself together or get yourself away from him.

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MARK: Just leave? I can't leave him.

BEVERLY: Why not?

MARK: I owe him.

BEVERLY: What? Pity? I mean, what's in it for you?

MARK: Nothing's in it for me.

BEVERLY: He's just a tired, sick old man . . . A tired old trick with some phoney ideas that don't hold water . . . a broken-down sewer, that's all he is.

MARK: I didn't say that . . .

BEVERLY: You don't need that. You don't need to dirty your hands with that kind of rotten putrid filth. Unless of course you need the money. What does he do – pay you by the month? Or does it depend on how much you put out?

MARK: . . . I don't want him to die. I don't . . . Please . . . I don't want him to die.

BEVERLY: Hopes, baby. That's what you got. A bad case of the hopes. They sneaked up on you when you weren't looking. You think maybe it's not gonna happen. You think maybe you'll find some way out. Some word that still alive, some word that will make it all different . . . Please, baby, just one favor you owe him. Don't hurt him. Don't hurt him with your hope. He needs somebody. That was my answer, too . . . Bye, baby.

MARK: Wait . . . .

BEVERLY: Tell Brian goodbye for me

MARK: Don't you want to see him?

BEVERLY: No, I've got a plane to catch. It's funny. He always makes the same mistake. He always cares about the wrong people.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
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KS State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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